

Replacing the whiteboard

BMIR is pointing participants to RideFinder instead of the ride-board whiteboard. A whiteboard can't match a rider to a driver, can't tell you when someone answers, and only works while you're standing in front of it. RideFinder does all three, and still works with no signal.

A computer station is available at BMIR for anyone whose phone is dead, dusty, or absent. Nothing to install and no account to create — post a ride, read replies, message a driver, then pick it back up later on your own phone.

1 How it works

- Browse.** Drivers offering seats on one side, riders looking for seats on the other. Filter by direction (heading in / exodus), day, city, and how much gear a ride can take. No login to look.
- Post.** Pick Driver, Rider, or **Cargo** — gear travelling without you — then the basics: date, 3-hour departure window, seats and gear. Posting creates your session; there is no signup screen.
- Connect.** RideFinder matches your listing automatically, and you message people privately inside the app.

Your session code — something like **dusty-camel-8214** — appears the first time you post. That code is the whole account. Type it into any other device to bring your listings, matches, and messages with you.

2 Auto-matching

Every time a listing is posted or edited, RideFinder scores it against every compatible listing heading the same way. It weighs:

- Date** — how close the travel days are
- Route** — not just same-city. It knows where Black Rock City is and measures the extra miles to collect someone en route, so a rider on the way still matches
- Gear** — whether the stuff physically fits in the vehicle
- Timing** — whether the departure windows overlap
- Freshness** — recently active listings rank higher

Each match gets a **0–100 strength score** and explains itself in plain English, so nobody has to trust a black box:

Same day Same area Gear fits Times line up

Matches are listed best-first in the **Matches** tab, with a banner on the board when new ones appear.

3 Private messaging

Tap **Message** on any listing to start a conversation inside the app — text, or a photo of the truck bed or the pile of bins. No phone number, no email, no social handle.

Contact details never appear on the public board. Sharing is per message and off by default — tick "share my email" or "share my phone" on one message and only that person receives it, as a tappable text / call / email link. Everything else stays private, and you can keep talking without ever sharing anything.

This is the part a whiteboard can't do: no phone number written in marker for the whole camp to read.

4 Email digest

RideFinder emails from **matching@ridefinder.site** only when something actually happened — a new message, or a new potential match. Each person picks the pace:

Instant Hourly (default) Daily Never

Digests group messages by conversation and carry links that drop you straight into the right thread, already signed in — handy if you posted from the BMIR station and are reading on your phone later. Every email can change your frequency or unsubscribe.

5 It works offline

The feature that matters most on playa. RideFinder installs to a phone's home screen like an app and keeps working when the network doesn't:

- The app and the last board you loaded open **instantly, with or without signal**
- An amber bar tells you how stale the data is — *"Offline — showing rides from 23 min ago"* — so you're never guessing
- Anything you post or send while offline is queued as **"Waiting to sync"** and sends itself exactly once when signal returns. Nothing is lost and nothing double-posts.

To install: Android/Chrome — accept the "Install RideFinder" banner or menu → Add to Home screen. iPhone/Safari — Share ↑ → Add to Home Screen. Best done in town.

6 Good to know

- Free.** No ads, no data selling, no accounts. A community project.
- Deactivate your listing** once your ride is settled — it takes the post off the board but keeps your messages. It's what keeps the board honest.
- Up to 5 posts a day, 3 active per direction, so nobody floods the board.
- Listings retire a few hours after the travel window; "show recently expired" brings back the last week.
- Something off about a post? Report it from the ... menu. Repeat reports hide it for review.